

DigiPick of the month

Takes
Two To Tango



This month's winner is
Saiyad Haider J
P.C.-114, P.O.Box-470
Jabroo,
Sultanate Of Oman

He wins
S.U.M.O
(Shut up, Move on)
by Paul McGee

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WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift just by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with the subject '**DigiPick**' and your postal address **on or before the 15th of this month** to **digipick@thinkdigit.com**. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

whether a person's heartbeat increases upon seeing a cockroach? How about finding out whether a man's gall bladder increases its secretions upon hearing of an impending visit from his mother-in-law?

Lockhart is "not interested" in using the results of the research to rate himself: "I prefer the old-fashioned way of doing that—hearing a sharp intake of breath from the audience... I'm an analogue guy in a digital age."

If this is what the digital age means, perhaps we're all better off being analogue...

WILL THEY TAKE OVER THE WORLD?

Armed Robots!

This is not the first time we've come across news of the sort that makes you feel the end is nigh, but

it's different: we're actually placing the guns in their hands. The robots', that is.

US troops have been doing some creative tinkering with the robots that help them in Iraq and Afghanistan: they've modified them to carry grenades and other weapons into buildings and other potentially unsafe targets. The military has not been unresponsive to these experiments: the Pentagon is now testing a new version of the Talon robot that carries a remote-control M-240 machine gun!

It turns out much larger robot weapons are also in testing, including a tank-like vehicle called the Gladiator, which can fire guns, tear gas or almost anything else.

These armed robots fire only with human command. But can the next step be far behind? More independent robots that decide by themselves when to fire? Now here's the scary part: having robots fight without

human control is "not a technology issue, so much as it's a safety issue," says Scott Myers, president of General Dynamics Robotic Systems. In other words, we already have most of the technology, and just need to work out how to keep it safe!

A robot can find a human with its sensors and kill the person, but "we don't want to shoot our own people or children," Myers says. It's hard enough for a human to distinguish between friend and foe, and far as the robots are concerned, "we're a long way from being there." Thankfully! Imagine newspaper headlines that said "Robot takes control, kills sergeant, four marines!"

JUST 272 SONGS

The RIAA's Getting Obnoxious

A student at MIT says the RIAA has "told her" to drop out and work to pay her fine for illegal downloading of songs! Sometime in December of last year, physics major Cassi Hunt, 20, learnt that she was being sued by the Recording Industry Ass. of America for illegally downloading 272 songs, MTV.com recently reported. Hunt hasn't admitted guilt, though.

The Ass. offered her a deal to settle the suit for \$3,750. But in addition to loans for her \$42,000 annual college expenses, Hunt said she makes only about \$5,000 a year working in between studies.

People Who Changed Computing

Programming Pioneer

Programming would probably have been very different if not



Edsger Dijkstra

for the contributions of Edsger Wybe Dijkstra. He was the first to bring about the

concepts of structured programming synchronisation, stacks and vectors, which are used in virtually all of programming today. He was one of the creators of the Algol 60 compiler: this was the second high-level programming language compiler, and became the reference for all future compilers.

Born in 1930 in The Netherlands, Dijkstra completed a PhD in Computer Science from the University of Amsterdam. During that time, he created a highly efficient "shortest path algorithm," which finds application in communication and electronics problems. In 1968, Dijkstra published his famous *Cooperating sequential processes*, the essay that kicked off the field of concurrent programming. Here he discussed the notion of mutual exclusion, and gave the first solution to the mutual exclusion problem for two processes. Further, he proposed the first synchronisation mechanism for concurrent processes, the semaphore.

Dijkstra received the ACM Turing Award in 1972. He was an exceptional writer, having written 1,300 works on computing—mostly on his typewriter, and later on, using his Mont Blanc fountain pen! His works were later digitally scanned and are available for reference to this day.

Dijkstra often spent vacations travelling with his wife in his Volkswagen Bus. He died in 2002, leaving behind research of unmatched depth, clarity and originality.